

REDEFINING AMBITION

Shashikant Ruia was a visionary entrepreneur who navigated challenges with resilience. He leaves behind a rich legacy of ambition and leadership

BY KRISHNA GOPALAN

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DESCRIBING SHASHIKANT RUIA

is no simple task. Perhaps he epitomised the quintessential Indian entre-

preneur: a sharp thinker adept at navigating complex systems with skill and charm. Ruia, who passed away on November 25, was a man of boundless ambition, bolstered by extraordinary grit and confidence.

His journey was remarkable. Together with his younger brother, Ravi, Ruia took on his first major project in 1969—constructing an outer breakwater at Chennai Port. From those humble beginnings, which saw him and his brother move the business from Chennai to Mumbai, although both the brothers retained the Tamil culture, he built a legacy spanning steel, oil,

shipping, telecommunications, and more—industries challenging even in the best of times. But this was pre-liberalisation India and the infamous Licence Raj was known to scuttle even the most resilient of the lot. But the constraints of the Licence Raj were no deterrent for Ruia; instead, he excelled in navigating through its bureaucratic labyrinth, leveraging strong relationships and his innate business acumen.

For anyone who thrived in that restrictive era without complacency, post-liberalisation India in 1991 offered unprecedented opportunities. Ruia seized them with vigour, achieving meteoric growth before eventual challenges reshaped the group's story.

In the late 1980s, Ruia embarked on establishing a steel plant. During this time, he met Ji-

tender Balakrishnan, then a promising young professional in IDBI's project finance department. "At first, he came across as tough, but I soon discovered his warmth," recalls Balakrishnan, who later spent years on Essar Steel's board, first as a nominee and then as an independent director. According to Balakrishnan, Ruia's success never changed him: "He remained down-to-earth and humble."

The 1990s marked relentless expansion for Ruia and Essar. However, in 1999, Essar Steel faced its first major setback, defaulting on \$250 million in floating rate notes. Three years later, the company entered corporate debt restructuring. But Ruia, ever the risk-taker, refused to retreat into conservatism. Emerging from the crisis, he pursued audacious ventures—acquiring mines, steel plants, BPO